Lesson 4 · Safer school WhatsApp groups · for your pupils

Our class group rules

40 minutes | Ages 10–16 · adapt for other ages below | No electricity needed | No devices needed | Photocopy-friendly

Big question

What rules keep a class group safe and kind?

Pupils will be able to...

- Explain why photos, marks and phone numbers should never be posted in big groups.
- Design five clear rules for a class group and explain each one.
- Describe how to check an urgent request and report a strange message.

You need

- Board and chalk (or a large sheet of paper)
- Large paper for the rules poster, and pens or chalk
- Six example posts on slips of paper (see prep)
- Worksheet: Safe group check (one per pair, optional)

Before class

Draw a large phone on the board with an empty group chat. Write six example posts on slips of paper: a class photo, a mark list, a homework reminder, a phone number, an "urgent money" message and a match result.

Time	What you do	What you can say	Pupils
Warm-up 0–5 min	Ask who is in, or knows of, a family, football or faith group chat. Ask: what is the group for, and who decides what gets posted?	*"Every good group has a purpose and some rules. What happens in a group with no rules?"*	Share groups they know; name problems like spam and unkind posts.
Teach 5–13 min	Read out the six example posts. For each, pupils vote: fine for a big group, share privately, or never share. Explain that photos, marks and numbers can be forwarded to anyone.	*"Once something is posted, anyone in the group can save it or send it on. So we think before we post."*	Vote on each post with thumbs up, sideways or down.
Rule makers 13–27 min	Groups of four write five rules for a class group: what it's for, who posts, what is never shared, how we treat each other, and what to do with a strange or urgent message.	*"Make each rule short and clear. Could a new pupil understand it in one reading?"*	Discuss, agree and write five rules.
Share 27–34 min	Each group reads its best rule. Build one class poster from the most popular rules, making sure it includes "check urgent requests with an adult" and "report and block strangers".	*"Which rule protects us most? Which one would you add?"*	Vote; help write the class poster.
Wrap-up 34–40 min	Exit ticket: each pupil writes one thing they will never post in a group and what they would do with a strange message. Everyone signs the poster.	*"These are our rules. Tonight, tell someone at home one of them."*	Complete the exit ticket; sign the poster.

Check understanding
Listen for reasons: "it can be forwarded", "it's private". If a rule is vague, like "be good", ask: "What exactly should someone do or not do?"

Exit ticket
One thing I'll never post + what I do with a strange message.

Common mix-ups

Pupils may think…	Help them see…
A group is private, so anything goes.	Anyone in the group can save, screenshot or forward a post. Ask: would I be happy if everyone saw this?
A message with the teacher's photo is from the teacher.	Anyone can copy a name and photo. Check with the real person face to face or on the number you know.
Reporting a message is telling tales.	Reporting protects everyone. Apps have report and block buttons, and telling a trusted adult is always OK.

Adapt it

Younger pupils
Ages 6–9: make three picture rules together — send kind messages, ask before sharing a friend's photo, and tell an adult about strange messages.

Older pupils and university
Compare your rules with the school's own policy, then list the settings an admin should choose: who sends, who edits and who approves new members.

Large classes
Give each row one rule topic. Rows write one rule each and send a speaker to the board.

No board or no space
Write the rules on a large sheet or on the ground outside; pupils add their initials or handprints as signatures.

Short on time? Do the six example posts and write three class rules together (20 minutes).

What you need to know

A school WhatsApp group is as safe as its settings and rules. Let admins control it, lock your account with a PIN, keep pupils' details out, and check urgent requests by phone.

Admin
A group member who can change the group's settings, add or remove members, and approve people who ask to join.

Privacy setting
A choice in the app's settings about who can see or do something — for example, who can add you to a group.

Two-step verification
An extra lock on your account. In WhatsApp, it's a six-digit PIN you choose, asked for when your number is set up on a phone.

Impersonation
Pretending to be someone else, such as putting a head teacher's name and photo on a new number to ask for money.

My notes — how did it go?